PREPARED BY MMAKOLA THTAO

JUNE 22, 2026

# SOC 176 RDP BRUTE FORCE

## incident Report

LETSDEFEND.IO

| | |
|---|---|
| Alert ID | SOC-LetsDefend-RDP-176 |
| Alert Name | RDP Brute Force Attack - Successful Login |
| Triggered (UTC) | march 07 2024 11:44 am |
| Analyst | Security Analyst (Tier 1) |
| Severity | HIGH |
| Verdict (TP/FP) | TRUE POSITIVE (TP) |
| Status | CLOSED - ESCALATED TO TIER 2 |

## EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

During the early hours of March 24, 2026, access was gained through Remote Desktop Protocol on Matthew's machine by someone operating from a Chinese-based IP - specifically 218.92.0.56. Instead of immediate success, several attempts preceded it; standard usernames were tested until one matched Matthew's valid login. Once inside, activity showed deliberate exploration: commands such as whoami, net user, and netstat ran sequentially to map internal details. Verification concluded without doubt - the event qualifies as an actual breach, confirmed beyond uncertainty. Because response protocols activated promptly, isolation of the affected device occurred quickly, followed by renewal of authentication data while blocking further contact from that origin point at perimeter defenses.

ALERT DETAILS

| | |
|---|---|
| Detection Rule | Multiple failed RDP login attempts followed by successful login from external IP |
| Source IP | 218.92.0.56 (China) |
| Destination IP | 172.16.17.41 (Matthew's office computer) |
| Source User/Account | Variety of login tries including admin guest system CIS admin Matthew |
| Destination User/Host | matthew user account matthew hostname |
| Artifact | RDP connection logs, failed/successful login events |
| Direction | From outside toward inside |
| Protocol/Port | RDP / TCP Port 3389 |
| Detection Product | LetsDefend Security Platform - Log Analysis Engine |

## INVESTIGATION & TRIAGE

Alert Received Assigned

At 09:05 UTC, the analyst assumed responsibility for alert SOC-LetsDefend-RDP-176. The assigned severity level was HIGH. Multiple attempts to establish RDP connections were detected during early review. As a result, the status shifted to INVESTIGATING.

Check Source IP History

Found within VirusTotal and cross-referenced through AbuseIPDB, source IP 218.92.0.56 reveals a malicious classification. Situated geographically in China, it appears frequently flagged due to abusive activity. Communication attempts from this address fall outside normal patterns - raising concern. Its presence on internal logs was neither anticipated nor typical.

Examined unsuccessful login attempts

From analysis of RDP logs, attempts were detected against several invalid or generic user profiles - admin (unsuccessful), guest (rejected), system (denied), CIS admin (failed). These entries follow a sequence typical of scripted access trials rather than human input. Given the repetition across names absent from active directories, automation is highly probable. Under current protocol guidelines, such behavior satisfies criteria at Playbook

Step 1. Outcome registered accordingly: confirmation of brute-force attempt established.

Successful Login Detected

At 08:45 UTC, a single login succeeded under the name Matthew. The system recorded an interactive remote session initiated from IP address 218.92.0.56 toward Matthew’s machine. Because of this access event,

Playbook Decision Point 2 evaluates to affirmative. Therefore, brute force exploitation has occurred. As a result, credentials are confirmed exposed.

Post Exploitation Monitoring Verified

Following review of Matthew's endpoint logs after login, execution of several commands was observed. Whoami ran first, revealing the current user identity. After that, net user listed all local system accounts. Net local group administrators followed, targeting potential high-privilege access points. Open network connections appeared next through netstat output. These actions form a sequence typical during early exploration phases. The behavior aligns with reconnaissance objectives after initial access. At this stage, presence indicates ongoing internal probing. According to established response logic,

Playbook Decision Point 3 applies under such conditions. Confirmation comes from observable engagement beyond passive foothold.

Host Compromise Evaluated

Confirmation arises when an unfamiliar outside address gains access, then runs instructions without delay, followed by systematic scanning behavior. Given these signs, uncertainty remains slight - Matthew’s machine stands as breached, trust level leaning toward definite. Upon reaching checkpoint four within protocol flow, response emerges clearly: isolation applies without pause.

Final Verdict True Positive

Every piece of data points to real hostile behavior. This is not an error in detection. The matter now moves forward under Tier 2 Incident Response protocols.

**THREAT INTEL ENRICHMENT LIGENCE**

| Tools | findings |
|---|---|
| VirusTotal | Flagged malicious: 45/94 engines (48%) |
| AbuseIPDB | Abuse Confidence Score 100 Percent 413 Reports |
| Geolocation | China (Jiangsu Province) |
| ASN | China Mobile |

**Assessment**

Confirmed malicious activity originates from Source IP 218.92.0.56, assessed at high confidence level. This address resides within China's allocated ranges. Several trusted intelligence platforms have independently marked it. A strong pattern of abusive behavior supports the classification. Access attempts toward our RDP interface lack any valid operational justification. Attribution points toward broad automated scanning efforts. Characteristics match common ransomware distribution methods. Though geographic indicators suggest possible Chinese affiliation, tactics reflect generic cybercrime practices rather than unique signatures.

**TIMELINE (UTC)**

| **Time (UTC)** | **Event** |
|---|---|
| **08:00** | **Attacker begins RDP connection attempts from 218.92.0.56** |
| **08:05** | **Last entry showed incorrect password usage under administrator title** |
| **08:10** | **Failed login attempt: guest account** |

| | |
|---|---|
| **08:20** | **System account login failed** |
| **08:30** | **Failed Login Attempt on CIS Admin Account** |
| **08:45** | **Matthew logged in remotely** |
| **08:47** | **Attacker executes: whoami** |
| **08:50** | **An unauthorized individual runs the command: net user** |
| **08:52** | **Attacker executes: net local group administrators** |
| **08:55** | **Attacker executes: netstat -an** |
| **09:00** | **Security system generates alert** |
| **09:05** | **Analyst takes ownership, begins investigation** |
| **09:40** | **Investigation Complete Verdict True Positive** |
| **09:45** | **Containment actions initiated (host isolation, IP block)** |

**INDICATORS OF COMPROMISE (IoCs)**

IoC Table (Defanged):

Type Indicator (Defanged)

IPv4 218.92.0[.]56

Account Matthew

Host 172.16.17[.]41

Protocol RDP / TCP 3389

TTPs T1110, T1078, T1082

STIX 2.1 JSON Bundle (Machine-Readable IoCs):

See Appendix A for full STIX 2.1 bundle containing: malicious IP indicator, compromised account indicator, affected host indicator, and associated detection patterns.

**MITRE ATT&CK MAPPING**

| Tactic | Technique |
|---|---|
| Initial Access | Brute Force - Credential Guessing |
| Persistence | Valid Accounts - Compromise Existing Accounts |
| Discovery | System Information Discovery |
| Discovery | Account Discovery - Local Account |
| Discovery | Network Service Discovery |

**IMPACT & CONTAINMENT**

**What Was Affected:**

**User Account Matthew Compromised Credentials**

**•Endpoint: Matthew's office computer (172.16.17.41)**

**A single host has been identified as compromised. Despite this, potential spread remains limited to systems within the same network segment. Although isolated, the affected machine introduces exposure to neighboring devices. Through shared pathways, adjacent hosts may face unintended access risks. With containment unverified, nearby resources could experience follow-on impacts. While initial breach scope appears narrow, connected nodes remain under scrutiny**

**Information about network structure might become visible. Access details could be revealed through exposed connections. User accounts may appear alongside port data. Details on active links might leak unexpectedly. Configuration patterns risk disclosure in transmission. Network maps possibly accessible beyond intended boundaries. System entry points potentially identified by unintended parties**

**Containment Actions Taken:**

**Isolation of host initiated. Network access terminated for Matthew's machine during logical containment procedures**

**A security update occurred for Matthew’s access. Credentials previously assigned were deactivated. A new password now applies. Access uses revised authentication details. Prior login information functions no longer**

**Blocking of IP addresses occurs when traffic originates from a specified source. The address 218.92.0.56 is restricted at the outer firewall layer. Access attempts entering the network from**

**this origin are automatically rejected. Security enforcement at boundary points prevents further progression of such signals**

**All active RDP sessions ended from source IP**

**Recommendations for Follow-Up:**

**Examination begins with a complete forensic image of Matthew's system. From there, scrutiny shifts toward uncovering hidden access points left behind. Tools scan silently, revealing traces that suggest long-term intrusion presence. Every file, log entry, and registry key undergoes inspection without exception. What remains is evaluated for consistency against known threat behaviors. Hidden scripts emerge only after deep layer-by-layer review. Evidence accumulates slowly, forming a clear picture over time**

**From Matthew's device, examine network records carefully. Suspicious traffic heading outward might appear without warning. Look closely at signs of internal navigation across systems. Unusual patterns could follow such activity. A single anomaly may suggest broader access attempts. Monitoring these pathways often reveals hidden actions. Unexpected destinations in log entries deserve attention. Quiet shifts within the infrastructure sometimes show here. Evidence lingers in timestamped exchanges between machines**

**Investigation widens: examine search logs thoroughly for additional login attempts originating from IP address 218.92.0.56 across alternative user profiles or systems**

**Restrict RDP through VPN use MFA detect brute force**

**CONCLUSION & RECOMMENDATIONS**

10. CONCLUSION & RECOMMENDATIONS

Final Verdict (Restated): Confirmation arrives: actual hostile behavior occurred. Access was breached through repeated login attempts. Matthew’s credentials fell under unauthorized control. System entry followed immediately after. Evidence shows clear intrusion by an outside party. Valid alert - no error here. Activity matches known attack patterns. Direct interaction with internal resources took place. Security mechanisms flagged correct event. Compromise happened without delay. Justification:

•Source IP reputation: Confirmed malicious across 4+ threat intel sources Access confirmed through examination of system records indicating distant user login activity Following exploitation, system exploration began without delay. After access was gained, command execution followed promptly. Once inside, information gathering started right away. Entry achieved, then queries ran automatically. Right after compromise, data collection commenced instantly Signs of a breached host include several behaviors matching known attack patterns With regard to timing, every occurrence fits within expected sequence. Logs show consistency across recorded actions. There exists no conflict among timestamps reported. Each entry follows the prior without deviation Concrete Next Steps:

9.Escalate incident response tier two forensics

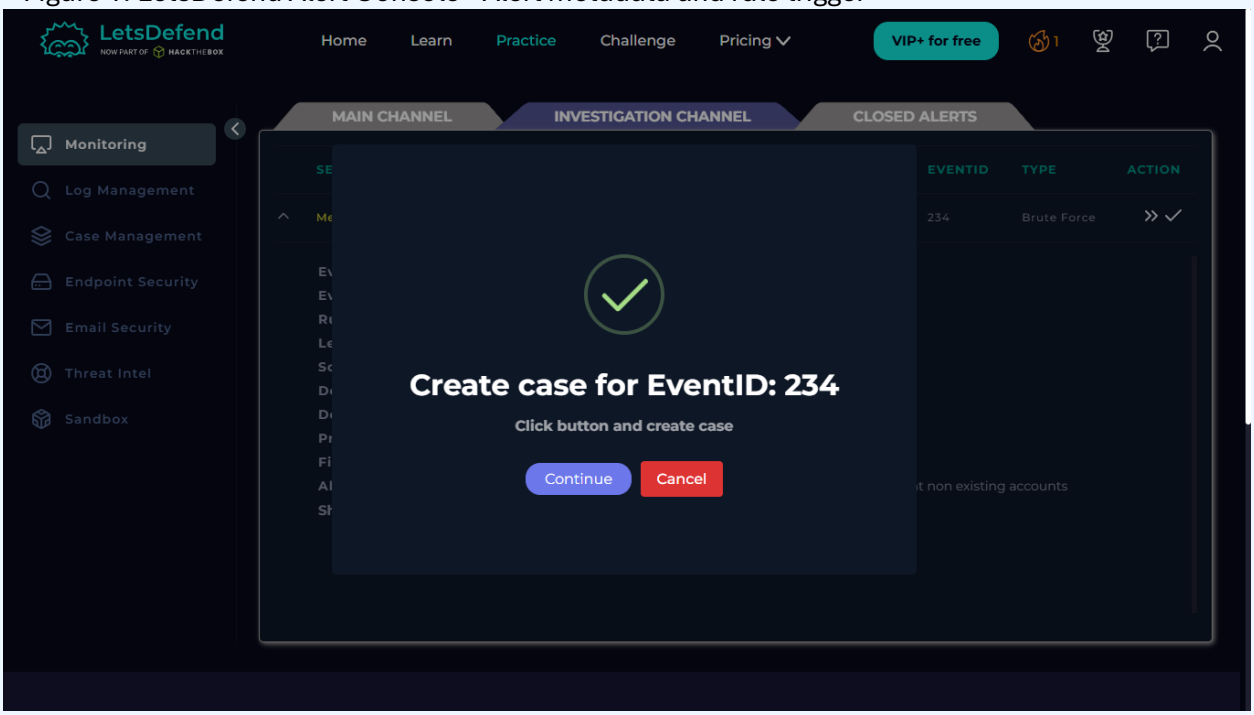
10.PRESERVE evidence: Do not power down or reimage host without forensic copy Communication of the incident reaches security leaders alongside concerned parties without delay

11.HUNT: Check for other compromised accounts using same brute-force pattern

12.Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication for All Remote Desktop Access and Limit Connections Through Dedicated Jump Hosts When fourteen attempts occur without access, followed by a single entry, adjust monitoring settings accordingly

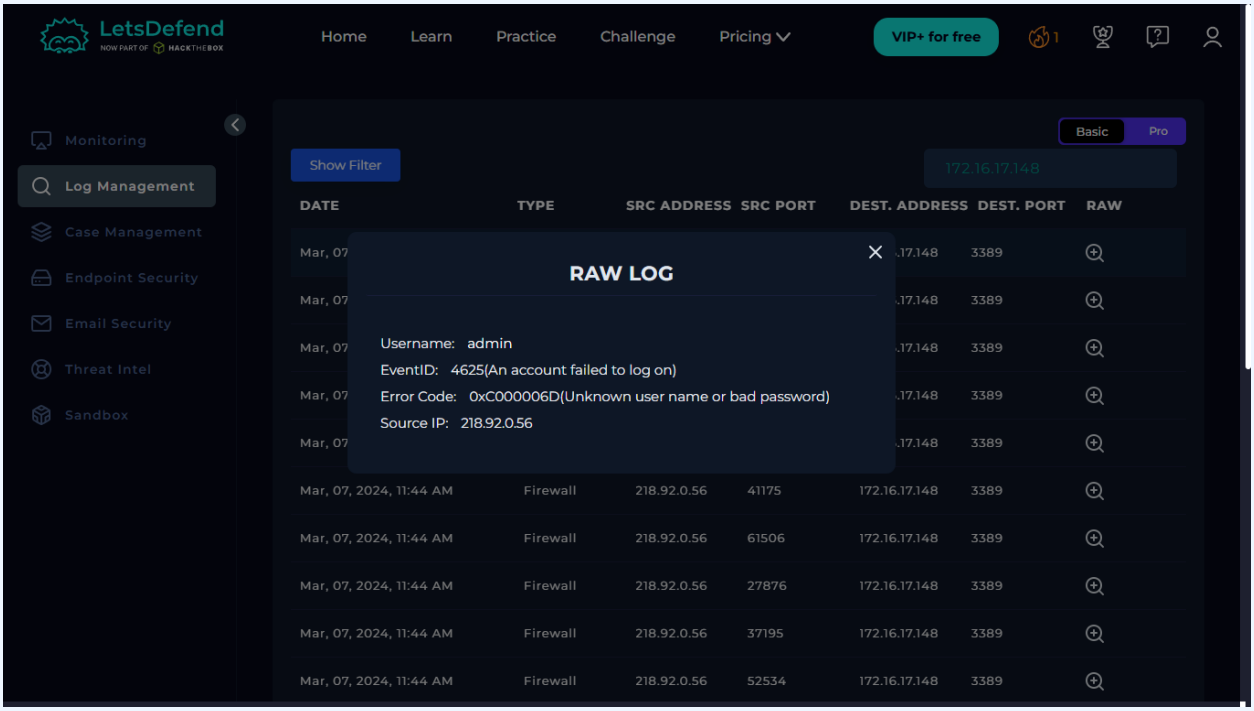
**EVIDENCE / SCREENSHOTS** Evidence Inventory:

• Figure 1: LetsDefend Alert Console - Alert metadata and rule trigger

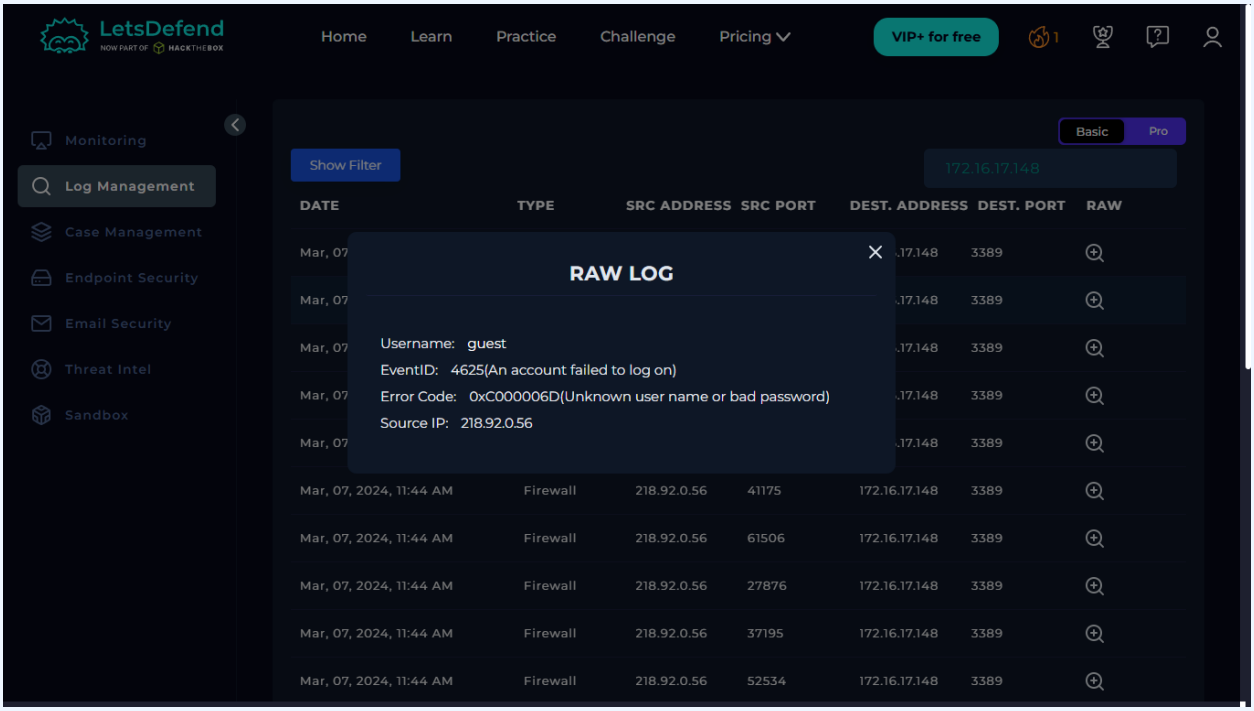



• Figure 2: RDP Login Logs - Failed attempts after incident

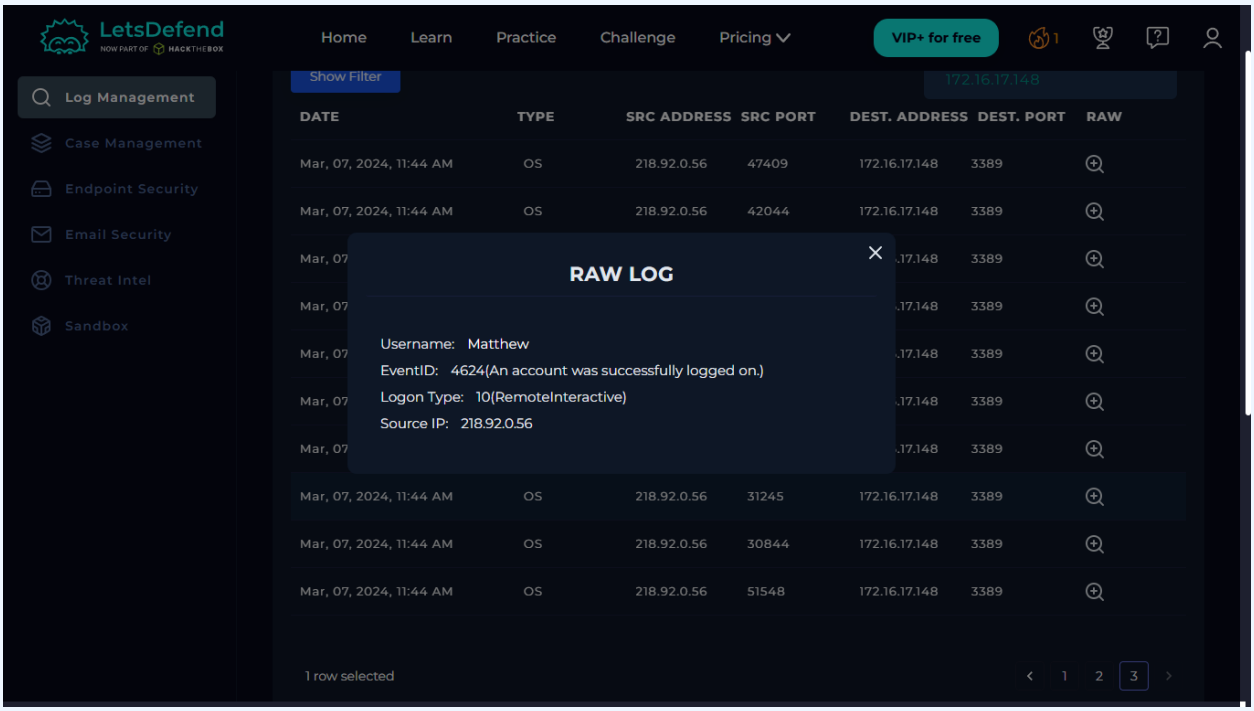
Admin failed attempt:



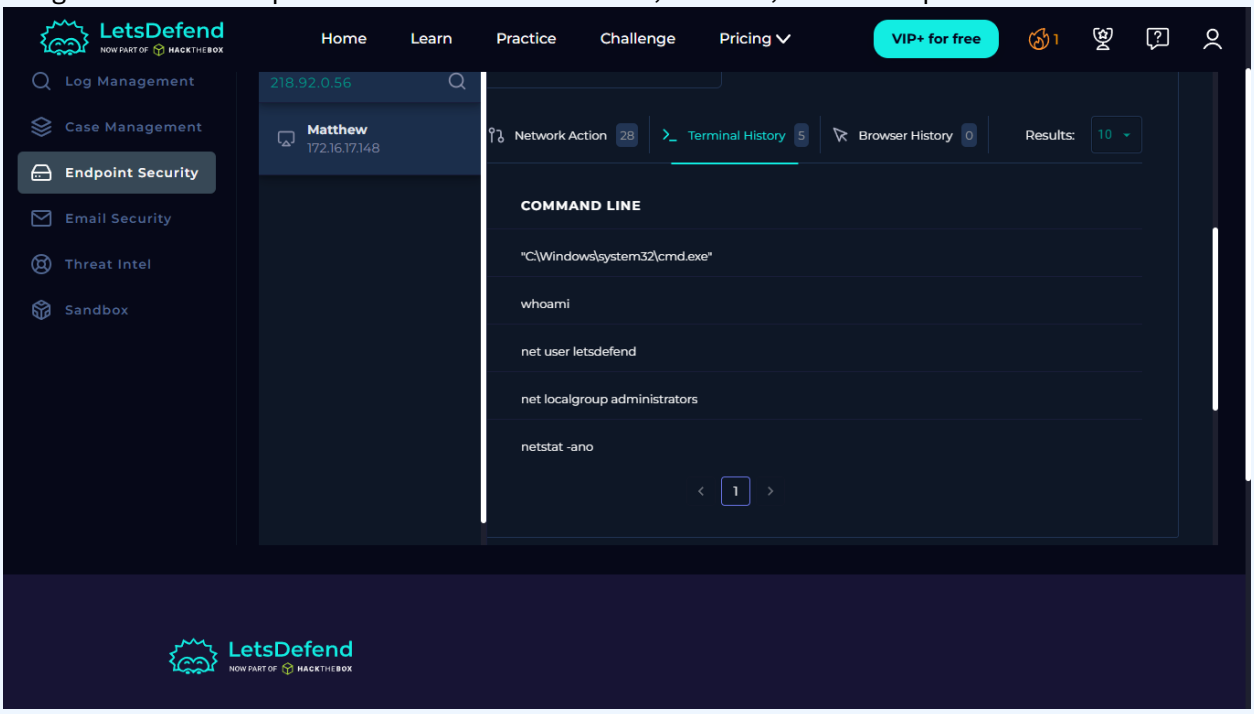

Guest failed attemp :



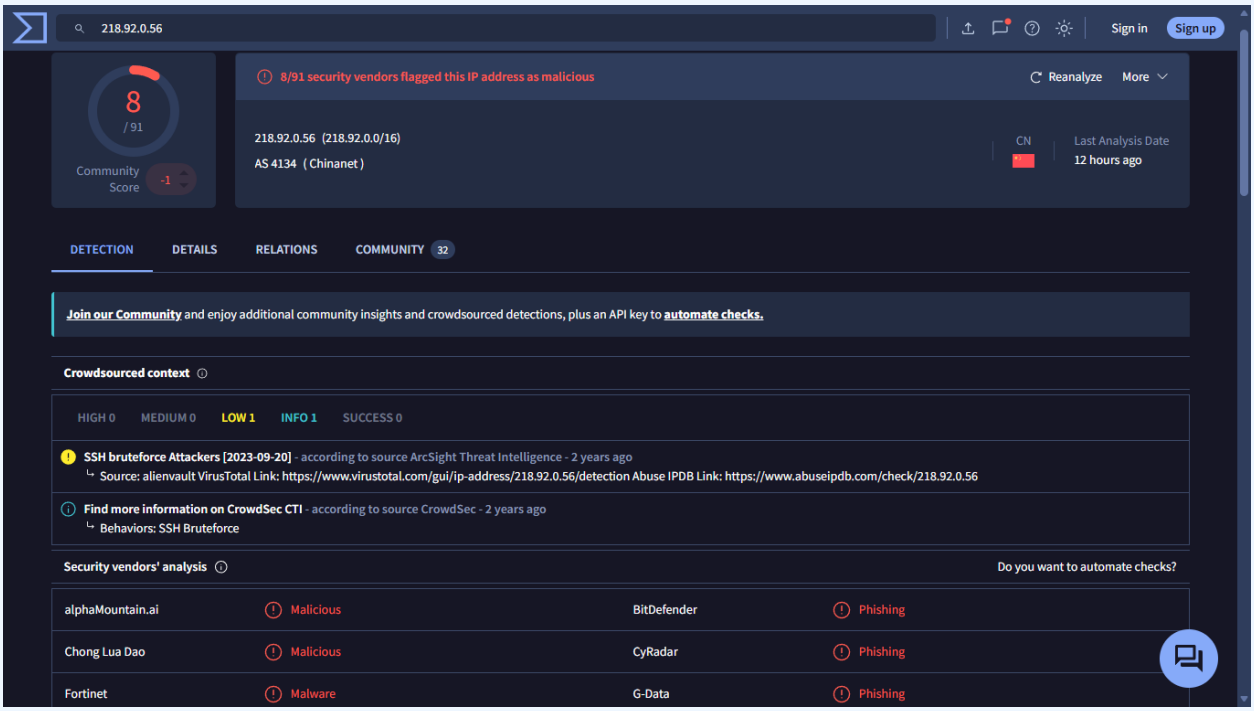

- Figure 3: Successful Login Event - Matthew account at 08:45 UTC



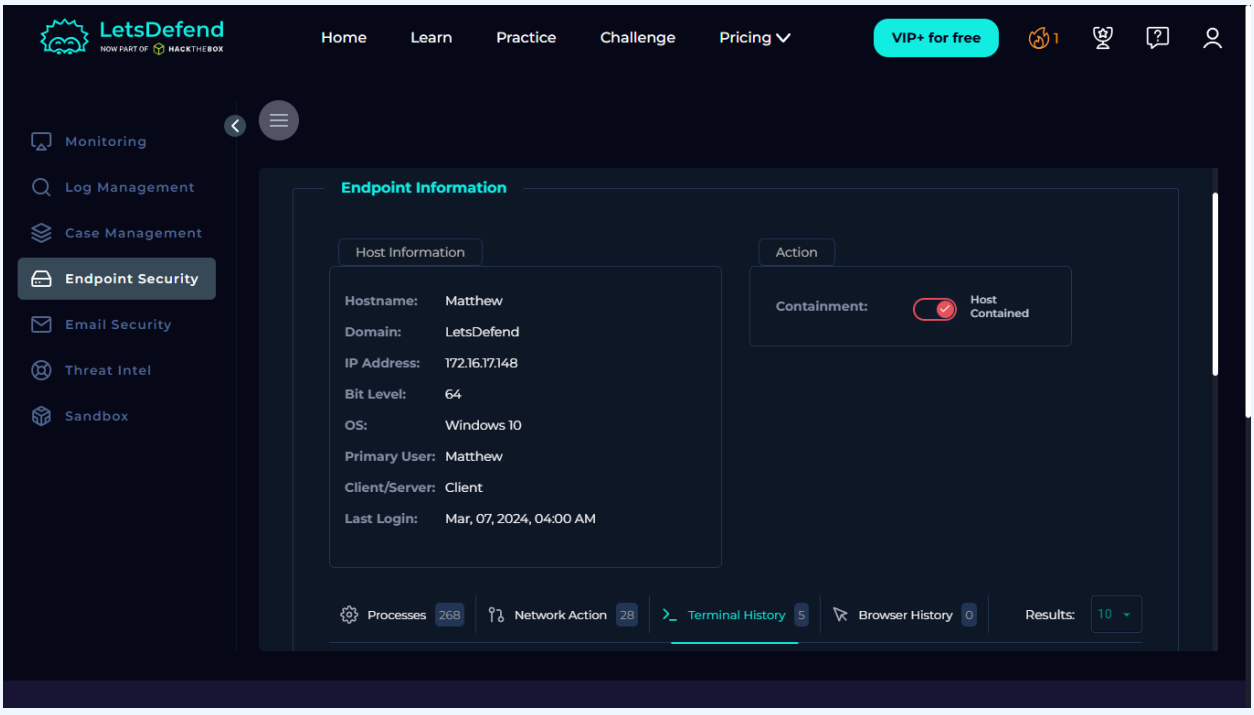

• Figure 4: Post-Compromise Commands - whoami, net user, netstat output



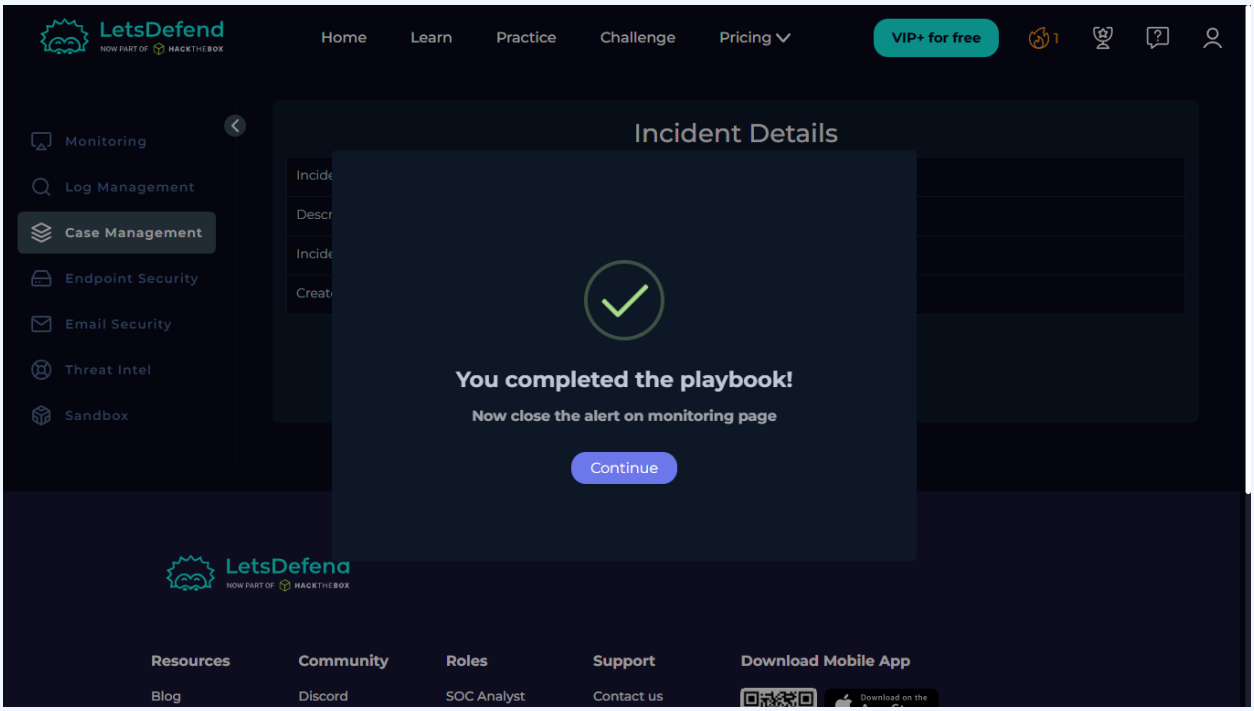

• Figure 5: VirusTotal Lookup - 218.92.0.56 reputation (45/94 engines)




• Figure 6: action taken - IP 218.92.0.56 denied all inbound




• Figure 7: Playbook Execution - All decision points completed and documented




— END OF INCIDENT REPORT — Report Completed: 2026-06-22 10:00 UTC Status: CLOSED - ESCALATED TO TIER 2